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Jimmy Wormworth

Drummer Jimmy Wormworth was born in Utica, New York and began playing professionally while still in his teens. Along with J.R. Monterose, Sal Amico and Torrie Zito, he is one of the many notable jazz musicians to come out of Central New York. Jimmy has played and recorded with Lou Donaldson and Lambert, Hendricks and Ross, and continues to live and work in New York City.

Jimmy was interviewed in New York City on January 6, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I've very pleased to have Jimmy Wormworth with me here. Welcome.

JW: I'm very pleased to be here. Thank you.

MR: I've been looking forward to this, because you know I've heard your name over the years so often, being up in Utica, and you making fortunate trips up there on occasion.

JW: Not lately, but yeah, I used to go up pretty frequently to visit my mother and my aunts and play gigs with J.R. and Sal Nistico.

MR: People talk about, up there anyway, they talk about how Central New York used to be a pretty good music avenue.

JW: Utica is remarkable. In the middle thirties in the height of the big band era, there were some really great musicians, some who came here and made a mark for themselves, Freddy Zito, Phil Olivello, a few. In the thirties in Utica my father played with Billie Holiday and Helen Humes. I know because I worked with Helen Humes later and she told me about it. "I knew your father." I said, "Well what'd you know about him?" "Well he was good looking." But he could play too. He never showed me a thing. I never lived with him. I didn't get to know him at all until I was a teenager out playing gigs with him. He had some pretty good background. He was very talented.

MR: It's interesting that you ended up playing the drums too.

JW: Yeah. My first love is the piano really. I really wish I was a piano player. I think certain instruments fit certain personalities. I've talked to drummers about it. I talked to Grady Tate. He said, "Yeah I'm cocky as hell." And most of the drummers I know, Art Blakey, they are definitely extroverts.

MR: Extroverts, for sure.

JW: And they believe in themselves a lot. They have a lot of confidence. Elvin. Now who's more confident than Elvin? Most of the drummers I know who I admire, they tend to have some swagger. Max definitely had swagger. And I think I have a short attention span. I tend to be intensely interested for a minute then all of a sudden I get distracted. I

think I have ADD. My colleague and friend Tardo Hammer, the piano player that works with Charles Davis, which is who I work with now, he said, "No I don't think you have ADD." I said I think I do. I can't concentrate.

MR: I don't know, you just move from one drum to the next you know. You've got enough drums there to take care of it I think.

JW: But a piano player can lay out when you're accompanying, or for that matter you can end your solo any time you want, and I think I'd be very suited for that. Plus I like to solo. And I have such bad feet I can't stand up so forget about trumpet, saxophone, bass and all that.

MR: Well you had not only your father was musical but also your uncle also?

JW: Dick Mariani, yeah, I think they had equal level of talent, which was, in my estimation a high level, both of them. So I'm not sure which side of the family I got the genes from, assuming I have any genes that are with musical talent. But I got it. Yeah, that's how my mother met my father. My mother and my aunts used to be sort of like in groupies because they came with the band in the big band era in the thirties and forties. And I think my Uncle Dick took my mother and maybe a couple of my aunts on one of his gigs, and my father was there, and my mother and father got hooked up. It was pretty revolutionary for that time, '36.

MR: Yeah. '36. Yeah.

JW: And my father never showed me anything, even though I know he was a great drummer. I saw him sit down and play for about a minute one time, just soloing, and I was flabbergasted. But he gave up the drums for the piano. He – how should I characterize it — I think he was something of a — I don't even know how to characterize it. He wasn't in the mainstream of society. He kind of functioned — although his parents were in black society in Utica. My grandfather was a church deacon and a thirty-third degree Prince Hall Mason, which is a — the Prince Hall Masons were the black counterparts of the Masons.

MR: The Masonic Temple, yeah.

JW: And a thirty-third degree level in Masonry is the highest level you can achieve, in both the Prince Hall Masons and the original Masons. And he died I guess close to a year before I was born and so I never got the chance to meet him but from what my mother and my aunts told me my father had a brand new Reo convertible in high school, and he and two or three other guys integrated Utica Free Academy, so I heard a couple of stories about that. He was kind of a spoiled brat, a scion of the black community, a well-to-do kid, and he was an only child and I think maybe partly conflicts, psychological conflicts about questions of race and his standing in his own community might have conflicted him

and caused him to have problems with himself. He became an alcoholic and — that's I think the main reason he gave up the drums.

MR: To get out of that life?

JW: Well no because he, sort of like Lester Young said well man, the girls will go around with all these other guys while I'm packing up the drums. My father was a little variation of that. He didn't want to carry all that stuff when he got a little feeling good at the end of the gig, so he ended up playing piano. And he played very well.

MR: That's right.

JW: And I, for whatever reason, neglected to ask Helen Humes when I worked with her whether my father had played piano with her or drums. I'm inclined to think he probably played piano with her.

MR: So singers like her and Billie Holiday, they would come through town and would pick up—

JW: They stayed in Utica for a period of time, or worked around that area, around Central New York. That's the impression I get. I'm sure you can find out about that somewhere.

MR: Yeah, right.

JW: So many of those people are gone now. My father was a close friend of Billy Kyle, the great pianist, and curiously enough I was a close friend of the late Al Haig and worked with him for a long time and became a really close personal friend. And one of his idols was Billy Kyle.

MR: Who were the musical people in Utica that you kind of looked up to at the time?

JW: Well I started getting out playing pretty early, playing with the older guys that is, the jazz musicians, when I was about 15 or 16. I think I met — well the first guys I met were Gordon Smith, Vic Kirch, and Vic Kirch's band when he still had the rock & roll band. My mother said, "Well you want to learn about this music you might as well go visit your father." So I went to one of his gigs at Thompson's in Whitesboro. And he had Gordon Smith and Billy Grimes playing the bass and my father playing piano. And the place was jammed with all the kids from Proctor High School and Whitesboro Central School and UFA, doing the 50s thing. The early 50s thing.

MR: So they would have been playing—

JW: Vic played music like Fanny Brown, Wynonie Harris, music, of the so-called race music of the early 50s. And the Utica kids ate it up. And I went in and he had this fabulous rhythm section. Gordon Smith was truly a great drummer. And he had lived, he had a heart defect and died Labor Day of 1959. I think he was 28. But if he had lived and had come to New York, which is where he was born, he really was a great drummer. To me his level of accomplishment, artistically, was that of an Arthur Taylor or Philly Joe even. He was distinctive. His style was easily recognizable when you heard him, and he was

fairly unique, not unlike an Elvin Jones or a Philly Joe. And he was pretty wise for his age too. He seemed old to me then, I was 17 then or 16. But he taught me things about life and music as well.

MR: When you got out and started playing can you recall what kind of money you would have made?

JW: My first gig, the first time I played for money I was 13 years old and we played at Wysocki's Restaurant on New Year's Eve in West Utica and it was a bunch of high school guys: Louie Angelini who I think is a professor of music at Utica College—

MR: Yes indeed.

JW: We didn't call him Louie, we called him Gino. That's 'cause his parents called him Gino. He lived near me.

MR: And he played piano?

JW: Played piano. Jimmy McIntyre, an alto saxophonist who I think ended up owning a music store somewhere near Richfield Springs or somewhere like that. Oh man — John Avolio, who I think became a music teacher and moved to Michigan, his father owned Avolio Electric near Proctor High School. The saxophonist was — gee I can't remember his last name, good as I know him — he once came in the Five — he became a school teacher too and he became, well he came in the Five Spot once when I was working there, in 1959. He was surprised to see me, I was surprised to see him. I think he was teaching in Mount Vernon or somewhere in Westchester. They became music teachers. They were in high school and I was still in grade school, and they hired me to play this gig with them. Jimmy McGuire, that was the saxophonist's name. Last I heard, quite a while ago, he owned a music store somewhere outside of Utica. But I guess by the time I was 16 I met Torrie and Ronnie Zito and I had started in high school taking auto mechanics, because one of my aunts said, "Well suppose you don't make it in music, you've got to have something to fall back on."

MR: The old fall back on thing.

JW: Exactly. One word. Fallbackon. Something like alpaca. But I listened to her and took auto mechanics for about 2-1/2 years in high school, totally wasting my time. I'm horrible in mathematics and you need to know geometry and stuff to be — you have to have machinist skills to be a really good auto mechanic and so forth. And I was a 98 pound weakling and couldn't loosen the bolts on engine heads and all that. And then finally I realized well this is a waste of my time. I love cars but I'm not good at it. I'm good at music. I'm a teenager and I'm playing with grown-ups, and they're telling me I'm good. So I switched to a music course I think in my senior year, or late junior year, had to sort of go back and start all over again.

MR: Was it at UFA?

JW: No at Proctor.

MR: At Proctor. Ronnie Zito went to UFA. We were best friends and it was like being on opposite sides of the country at that time as a teenager. But I started the music courses, took Rudiments of Music and History of Music and so forth. The rudiments teaches you key signatures and so forth, before theory where you learn harmony and all that. And I got this bug that I wanted to write some arrangements, like Gerry Mulligan's quartet with no piano. And I did, just by sort in my head solfeggio. And somehow I got some guys in my high school who played in the orchestra to come to my house and try to play the arrangements. And they didn't have a clue. It sounded pretty horrible. The notes were all right but their phrasing, they didn't have a clue. They weren't interested in jazz, and they weren't really talented they just happened to play instruments. And then I don't know, somehow I got hooked up with Ronnie and Torrie Zito and I went to their house and brought my arrangements and they played them and I said, "That's the best?" That was my last foray into writing. But I guess that sort of was like my entree into meeting Sal Amico and Vic Kirch. J.R. was always living in New York and Ernie Washington, and Gordon Smith and these other guys. Ernie Washington was truly a great artist, a great pianist who had some of the greatest facility. He could play as fast as anybody I ever heard, and he played trumpet too as a hobby, but when he played trumpet he sounded to me like Idrees Sulieman, the big fat sound and it sounded like he blew hard. Curiously enough his embouchure was over here not in the middle. But he had a piano studio in New Haven near Yale and taught privately and I think he was from Philadelphia. And he grew up with those older guys, the Heath brothers, and he once told me that the first place Charlie Parker ever stayed in New York was at Ernie's apartment here in New York. And that's really a shame that he didn't get well documented. He was a friend of Ray Bryant and John Dennis. John Cowth Dennis, who died young but who was a contemporary of Ray Bryant. He was also from Philly, John Dennis. And there was a small place in Little Falls called The Corner Tavern and a friend who had a car drove me there a couple of times and said, "You can't believe some of the pianists they're bringing in here, just guys doing a single." And the two guys I saw were Ray Bryant and John Dennis. It was just astounding.

MR: Wow, in Little Falls, New York.

JW: Yeah.

MR: Did you have a sense like I have to get out of Utica?

JW: Well I started going to Syracuse when I was 16, 17, going on the weekends and I met people, guys who I'm sure you heard of, who are probably not familiar to anybody outside of that area, Sy Simpson the drummer — there was a club called The Embassy, right near where the Everson museum is now, maybe on the same spot. It was around the

time when Jim Brown played football for Syracuse and that was his hangout place. He got to know a lot of the local people. He knew my wife and sister-in-law really well, and people who eventually became in-laws of my wife and sister-in-law. And the musicians there were Scott LaFaro, who was still living at home in Geneva, and a pianist named Joe Close who became Jack Jones' musical director for quite a long time in the 70's, and a trumpet player who I heard recently died from Pittsburgh who grew up with the Turrentine brothers, his name is Pete Henderson. And Pete Henderson and Joe Close were in the Air Force stationed at Sampson Air Force Base which was in Geneva. And that's how they got to know Scott LaFaro. And they used to come to Syracuse on the weekends to play just like I came from Utica to play in Syracuse. And that was a pretty regular thing for me for almost two years, getting a chance to play with Pete Henderson and Scott LaFaro definitely helped cultivate my —

MR: Well you ended up playing with one of your childhood heroes, or heroines should I say—

JW: Yeah. Nellie Lutcher.

MR: Nellie Lutcher.

JW: Uh, in 1946 around January, not long after Christmas, one of my uncles who was stationed in the Pacific in World War II came home and with some of the money he had saved from his allotment, which he sent to my grandmother, not long after he got home he was influenced by probably my Uncle Dick and maybe my aunts, to buy a record player, well what in those days was called a combination. It's a console record player and radio, when there was still 78s. It was the latest thing. Zenith. And so he bought this record player and radio combination and I can remember on the weekend, probably around March of '46, which was maybe two or three months after my uncle was discharged from the service and came home, my mother and one or two of my aunts and my Uncle Dick and my Uncle Alfred went to the Melody House record store, which used to be on Blandina Street, just off Genesee Street, just east of Genesee Street, and they were having this huge sale on records. And the records were all 78s then. And I can remember going there with them and they just bought up all kinds of records. And the records ranged from Tommy Dorsey's band with one or two records where Buddy Rich played solos, to I guess Tommy Dorsey's band with Jo Stafford and all kinds of records, including Nellie Lutcher's latest hits, an album on Capitol-Americana of Art Tatum and a whole bunch of Nat Cole trio singles. And I think that's really when my obsession or my interest in playing really took off. I think I was nine or ten. And I just gravitated toward these Nat Cole trio records and Nellie Lutcher's trio records, which were big hits. Nat Cole was pretty popular but that was before he became just a singer and stopped playing. But it was after he was just a pianist and played with Jazz at the Philharmonic and made records with whoever. He was a great pianist, I think that's pretty indisputable. I think

that's why he was such a good singer. He had a good instrument, good vocal chords and such knowledge. So those records and those Art Tatum records just took me off in the whole direction of music. I used to beg — I was spoiled rotten — and I'd beg my mother and my aunts, "Oh I don't feel good, could I stay home from school?" "All right honey, what's wrong?" And I'd stay home and all I would do is play those records over and over, and play passages. I got to the point when I was about 11 where I had a lot of the passages memorized, Art Tatum passages and whole Nat Cole records, each record memorized, the solos, the vocals, the intro, the endings.

MR: That's fascinating.

JW: And it just sort of went on from there. I really can't remember what influenced me after the period where I first discovered those Nat Cole and Art Tatum and Nellie Lutcher records. There was a period like I guess from the time I was 12 or so to when I started playing that I don't remember listening to any newer records. Around 14 I started getting interested in some of Gerry Mulligan's work and Shorty Rogers' Giants, And that's when I started trying to write, when I was about 15 or 16. But that interested me. And Dave Brubeck's octet interested me for a while. And then I think by the time I was 16 or so, that was when I met Gordon Smith and Ernie Washington and Sal Amico and those guys and they told me well look man, you've heard of Charlie Parker, now you're going to have to check him out. And the first time I heart Charlie Parker and Dizzy or whoever, it sounded so futuristic to me. I could tell that technically it was virtuosity, but I don't think artistically it made an immediate impression on me. But it wasn't long after that that it did. And to me Charlie Parker and Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington are — what do you call them — the beacons of the music? The arbiter? It took me to middle age before I could appreciate artists from the period of music that came before the period I grew into, except for Art Tatum and — well Art Tatum to me was the precursor of Bebop. And Nat Cole already could be considered a Bebop player. To me he grew out of that Earl Hines school. To me there were two schools, the Art Tatum percussive school and the Earl Hines lyrical sort of flowery school. And to me Bud Powell came from the Art Tatum school and Tommy Flanagan or Nat Cole came from the Earl Hines school. But well Charlie Parker, without much time put in listening to him, just mesmerized me. I mean he was definitely a musical genius. And then I was just really hooked on the music that started with him and came after, the so-called hard bop.

MR: Well tell me what it is like to go out and start playing with — when you started playing with Nellie Lutcher, you were how old?

JW: Twenty.

MR: Okay.

JW: I was pretty self confident. Some people would describe it as jerky or conceited maybe.

MR: Yeah?

JW: But well I loved her music and it was such a pleasure to play it and I considered myself fortunate to have fallen into this position where I could play with somebody whose music I knew so well and whose music I loved, whose work I loved. And I guess I considered myself pretty fortunate but I think somewhere in the back of my mind I thought I deserved it as well. It was pretty easy to me. I had really good chops. I had excellent training, technical training, from the late George Clisskins, who was Central New York's — in my estimation — was Central New York's greatest drum and percussion teacher.

MR: Was he pretty demanding?

JW: Yeah, but you either took it or left it. He told you what was required and either you did it or he cut you loose. Well you want to play or don't you? This is what you have to do for next week. He'd put an "O" on the page of work you were supposed to accomplish until your next lesson which was about a week, and then he'd put a "K" if he thought you mastered whatever exercises he had given you.

MR: That's neat.

JW: And I don't think I remember practicing at all. I can remember one of my aunts threatening me to practice, so I must have practiced some, but I know I went through his whole course in about 2-1/2 years, from 10 to about 12-1/2, and it included a few books. It started out with a book he had written, a beginner's book that taught you four strokes, and then taught you how to put the strokes together to make up the 26 rudiments, and then he used the Haskell Harr books which were pretty well known in that time period, the 50s, late 40s early 50s, and then he put me through George Lawrence Stone's stick control, which is a pretty renown book, most accomplished drummers know of it, even if they didn't study it, which I think a lot of drummers did. He was based in Boston, George Lawrence Stone, and it seems to me all the drummers I know who came from Boston, Alan Dawson, Tony Williams, who else, a couple of others, were really accomplished technicians, could play fast and complicated, and I can't help — oh Roy Haynes of course — and I can't help but think that George Lawrence Stone's teaching and his book in particular influenced those guys.

MR: When you were out on the road, let's see this would have been the 50s?

JW: I went out with Nellie in January of '58 for four months and then let's see, I guess Christmas of '58, the Christmas holidays, three weeks, I went to Chicago for three weeks with Phineas Newborn.

MR: What were the accommodations like at that time?

JW: Curiously enough, with Nellie we occasionally stayed in the top rated hotels, but occasionally Morris and I would have to stay at a rooming house or for example in St. Louis at a black hotel in a black neighborhood. In St. Louis we couldn't circulate in the

club, only Nellie could. We had to stay in the kitchen. And in Miami, Ohio, New Miami, Ohio, outside of Cincinnati, where the University of Miami of Ohio is, it was the same thing. Yeah it was pretty curious. And in Kansas City it was the same thing. I remember Nellie stayed in a Hilton or whatever, a Sheraton or whatever, downtown, and we stayed in a black hotel in I guess the black district near the club where we were appearing.

MR: Did it anger you at the time?

JW: I think I resented it. I was kind of new to that. I really grew up with my white side of the family. I was treated like with privilege and I was pretty much accepted by the kids in the neighborhood, I was just another kid in the neighborhood. I faced discrimination. I didn't have any dates until I got out of high school. But that definitely surprised me. Well that was 1958 and I thought that was kind of late in the day.

MR: But it wasn't as far as Civil Rights.

JW: But it wasn't as far as the Civil Rights movement, really, or before what's come to be referred to as the Civil Rights movement.

MR: Right.

JW: I think there always was a Civil Rights movement. Marcus Garvey.

MR: Right. Well tell me how Lambert, Hendricks & Ross came about.

JW: Well from what I understand, I was their second drummer. I took Walter Bolden's place. That was after they had recorded their first Columbia album "The Hottest New Group in Jazz." From what I understand Jon had moved to New York, Dave had lived here, I'm not sure if he was from here but he had lived here, and he wrote, I'm sure it's fairly common knowledge that he wrote the arrangements for Charlie Parker's "Old Folks," the vocal arrangements and a few others. And on the record I think the vocal group is called The Dave Lambert Singers. And so he was known for vocal writing and I guess organizing choral groups, jazz oriented choral groups, and Jon I think had just moved to New York not too long before he and Dave met up. I'm not sure how they met up. I think maybe it could have come from Annie influencing Dave through her vocalese work, "Twisted," I think she had done that on the west coast with Wardell Gray and Art Farmer I think. And she was the niece of Ella Logan, the Hollywood actress, and Annie was British — well I think she had dual citizenship. But at any rate she spent her childhood here in LA, in the movies, she was in the "Our Gang" comedies. She was one of the "Our Gang" kids. And I think she more or less grew up in LA and Hollywood, and pretty much she became a jazz singer. And then I guess she moved to New York I guess in the middle 50s or whatever. I'm not sure how that whole stuff coalesced, but they — it's been written about.

MR: Yeah, but you ended up with them after their first Columbia—

JW: After their Columbia album was half completed. That was after they had made their records on Verve or I forget, ABC Paramount, "Sing a Song of Basie," "Sing Along with Basie." "Sing a Song of Basie" was the multi-track overdubbing. "Sing a Song of Basie" was with Basie's band but I think Nat Pierce played piano not Basie, and Joe Williams sang, and Jon Dave and Annie didn't overdub anything they just sang along with the band I think. And then they were signed — that was such a splash, I can remember hearing them on the radio all the time before I ever knew any of them. Curiously enough Jon Hendricks came into the Five Spot a few times when I was working there from January through May of '59 with Mal Waldron as the house rhythm section, but I didn't know who he was, and I had heard this guy Jon Hendricks, Jon Hendricks this, Jon Hendricks — and I said who is this Jon Hendricks? And who is this guy who comes in the Five Spot all the time glad-handing everybody. Eventually I would get it. But yeah they were a big hit and they were favorites of some influential people — Hugh Hefner loved them. And we played at his festivals and I think they won the *Playboy* jazz polls back then and we went to his house before he moved to LA two or three times, on the north side, near the north side of Chicago. We were on his original variety talk show "Playboy's Penthouse Party" which I think was a syndicated program. I think it came on here in New York on WOR, which is now the WB channel — no not the WB, UPN9. Well Gil Mahones recommended me. And we had worked together before that with Les Jazz Modes, a quintet that Charlie Rouse and Julius Watkins co-led. And when I first got here I can remember seeing their album covers in the window of The Bohemia, they were like, well they created some stir. They were a little novel, the saxophone and French horn with complicated arrangements. And I kept seeing and hearing about them — Le Jazz Modes — and one time at a jam session open to everybody at Count Basie's Lounge in Harlem Charlie Rouse came up to me and asked me if I was interested in working with his group. I of course knew who Charlie Rouse was. I had had a couple of 78s with him and Fats Navarro when I was a teenager, and I was honored, I said yeah, of course. And I worked with them for, I don't know, a couple of years, played some concerts. We played the Newport festival, that was the first time I ever played at Newport. And Gildo was the pianist. And I had heard of Gildo because there used to be broadcasts in the 50s from Birdland and you could get them on the radio in Utica, AM broadcasts. And I heard Count Basie's band when Sonny Payne had just joined the band. To me he revolutionized the whole feel of the band. He sounded sort of like a Bebop drummer, even though when you heard him by himself in a small group he sounded like he came from an earlier era, but he made the band sound almost like Dizzy Gillespie's big band, like a Bebop band. And I can remember hearing Lester Young's group from Birdland as well, broadcasting, with Jesse Drakes playing trumpet and Gildo playing piano and Connie Kaye playing

drums, and I think John Ore was the bassist. And so I knew who Gildo was while I was still a teenager before I ever moved to New York. And then I got to meet him and we became friends. And he recommended me — he took the job with Lambert, Hendricks and Ross I guess sometime in '58 or late '58 maybe. And he recommended me when Walter Bolden left. And they hired me. And the first thing I did with them was I think I played a Monterey Festival. We left New York and drove all the way across country to Monterey and played that and then we came back to New York and finished that "Hottest New Group in Jazz" album, their first Columbia album. So Walter Bolden had done half and I did the other half.

MR: Okay. Did you play on—

JW: I played on "Gimme that Wine," "Sermonette," gee I can't even remember what else. Walter played on "Cloudburst," "Charleston Alley," "Centerpiece" I think.

MR: Good record.

JW: Yeah. It is a nice record.

MR: Was everything done together at that time?

JW: Yeah. Oh yeah. There were no booths then, no rooms. The Columbia studio is huge. It was formerly a church and — I don't remember when Columbia bought it, but that was when Columbia was really Columbia, when Goddard Lieberson was the president of Columbia Records, and the engineer was the German guy, Fred Plaut. Irving Townsend was I think head of jazz A&R. And this huge church, it was like a big auditorium, an empty auditorium with just recording equipment, baffles and so forth. And we just recorded, all together. There were no booths in those days as far as I can remember. I recorded a few different places with different people, with, Les Jazz Modes, we recorded for Atlantic and the late Neshuhi Ertegun was the A&R man, what's now called the producer I think. Yeah it's curious, my daughter Holly is the Director of Urban Markets for Atlantic Records now.

MR: No kidding.

JW: Yeah. She wrote a letter to Ahmet Ertegun, I think trying to get him involved in the Robin Hood Foundation to donate pictures or something for auction by the Robin Hood Foundation and she mentioned, well my father recorded for Atlantic in 1958 with Les Jazz Modes and your late brother Nesuhi was the A&R man. Rosh used to call him Nashwa.

MR: What were they like, as the three personalities? Did they mesh pretty well?

JW: Not in my estimation. Well on stage they did, yeah, they meshed fine on stage. Jon and Dave were at each other's throats a good part of the time. Their personalities were different. They clashed. Annie was above it all. She was regular. She didn't care what they did, as long as they left her alone to do her thing. That's off the stage. Dave was

intense, curious, he could fly into a rage. I remember one time we were coming from Pittsburgh, Dave and I caught a flight home. My kids were small and I was on the road so much. And it was Christmas time and I didn't want to have to drive home the next morning from Pittsburgh, that's another whole day wasted. So Dave and I rushed to the airport and caught a flight home. And we were the last people to get on the plane. And the plane is taxiing away from the gate almost to the runway and everybody's supposed to be in their seats with their seatbelt on and trays folded up. I don't even remember if they had trays in those days. But anyway Dave is stuffing stuff in the overhead rack. He's standing in the aisle and he's getting himself settled. And the stewardess comes rushing up, "Sir, you're supposed to be seated, the seat belt sign is on" blah blah blah. And he cursed her out so badly, I couldn't believe it.

MR: If he did that now he'd be tossed right off.

JW: Yeah how about that. It's like Charles Davis said the other day, he said, "Well look man, if you got to meet your friend Jack on the plane and then you meet up on the plane, just don't say 'hi Jack.'"

MR: Oh jeez.

JW: Well I laughed, I said that's a good point. I'll take that seriously.

MR: What did the typical gig pay in the late 50s?

JW: At the Five Spot I made $90 per week, six nights a week. That was 1959. So I have to figure that's like six or seven hundred dollars a week now. I could live easily off $90 a week at that time.

MR: Really.

JW: My rent was $85 a month. The first apartment I had in Brooklyn, a five room apartment, was $65 a month in 1960. A quart of milk was 24 cents. Subway was a nickel. The *Times* was a nickel. In fact the *Times* was a nickel into the 60s.

MR: And how about a recording session? Can you recall?

JW: I think they paid $151.50 for three hours.

MR: Well that was pretty good money.

JW: That was very good money for then. That was more than two months rent for my Brooklyn apartment. It was good money.

MR: But you personally, would you get any money from the record sales or anything like that?

JW: No not me. Just the composer, the artist, I never got into that hardly at all with any people I worked for. Nowadays it's a complete free-for-all even though the record companies have such a — all the media companies have such a strangle hold on the arts in general and music in particular. I mean but by the same token now there's the Internet, there's CD recorders that you can have at home, you have so many little recording studios that people set up on their own who have made a little money. So while on the one hand the

industry seems to be so much more controlled than ever before, to me, by the same token there are options now that I don't think there were twenty or thirty years ago, for the individual artist to try to put his work forth. I've had an experience with Larry Ridley, who I worked with, and Charles Davis as well, they both made CDs in the past two or three years on their own. And Larry started selling his on e-Bay and he recently told me he was nominated for a Grammy, I don't know if that's for this year or last year or whenever. So there are all kinds of —

MR: Yeah there's ways to do it.

JW: Is it possible to take a break for two seconds?

MR: Yeah, sure, absolutely. Just unhook your —

[pause]

MR: Let me throw a couple names at you and see just your recollections. Lou Donaldson?

JW: He was kind of a spiritual and artistic father to me. I met him the same way I met Charlie Rouse. Well first of all before I left home Torrie Zito was working in the strip joints and all that and writing arrangements for some of the acts in those strip joints in Rome and Utica, and made good money, and would buy up all of the latest Blue Note records and whatever, Verve records. He'd order them from New York, mostly because you couldn't get them in Utica too much. And so I'd go to visit Ronnie and Ronnie and I would lie on the floor in front of the phonograph and listen to all these records. And that's where I first heard Lou Donaldson. I guess that Thelonious Monk record where they play "Round About Midnight" and "Eronel" — which is Lenore spelled backwards. I've asked around, who's Lenore. I think somebody knows. I think Larry Ridley knows or Charles Davis. So that was my introduction to Lou Donaldson. And needless to say he impressed me. I loved his playing. I guess he had come to New York not too long before that and was an instant hit and when those records "A Night At Birdland" with Art Blakey, Horace Silver, Lou and Clifford Brown came out, well I was just in love with — well the whole record, but Lou included. And I came to New York and Lou is one of those people who is always out. He totally lives the jazz life, playing, everything, socializing. And he was always out at the jam sessions. And it just so happened when I came to New York a whole wave of guys came to New York who ended up doing very well — Freddie Hubbard, Larry Ridley, oh so many, and guys who from around here — Wayne Shorter, who was just getting out of the Army at the time. I can remember him playing jam sessions in his Army uniform, his summer khakis , getting up on the bandstand and playing in his summer khakis. I can remember Coltrane being back in the corner just listening and smiling and while Wayne is breaking the whole place up with this outlandish stuff. Curiously enough, my daughter ended up working with Wayne doing a couple of tours with him with his fusion band. And well anyway, Lou was always there and I knew who

he was but I never tried to introduce myself or anything. I don't think we did that in those days. But he came up to me and asked me to work with him. I think that was after Rouse asked me to work with him. Yeah it was after, because I remember I didn't have a local musician's union card. And to get one you had to transfer from your home town local, put in a formal, what they called a transfer. You might have switched from your home town local to the New York local and you had a probationary period where you couldn't work a steady job, you could only work — you could work every night, but not in the same place. You couldn't have a steady job. You could work all kinds of individual engagements, single engagements. And I think you could work steady weekends for two nights, maybe three nights. But you couldn't work four, five or six nights or seven nights in one place. And I put my transfer in and worked a little here and there. And now I got the job with Nellie, which meant that I went out of town, so my transfer was voided. I had to start all over again when I came back. And maybe a month and a half or so after I came back I met Charlie Rouse and he asked me to play in his group and I said I don't have the union card, the Local 802 card. He said oh I can straighten that out. He was booked — Les Jazz Modes were booked by Joe Glaser I think, ABC Booking, and so that the agent who handled the jazz accounts just called up the union and told them well we're sending somebody there, give him a card. And I can remember going up to Max Aarons' office, who was I think the secretary, and Charlie Rouse told me, just meet me at the union floor, Wednesday, blah, blah, blah, and we'll go up to Max Aarons' office and he'll give you a card. And we did and we walked in and Max said, "Oh well he looks like a nice boy, okay, you're accepted."

MR: A tough audition.

JW: Yeah. That was the start of how I became so cynical. But I met Lou Donaldson the same way. He just came up to me and asked me to work with him. And he had a steady engagement at a small place in the South Bronx, and he was using an organ. It was an organ trio format. And he asked me to work with him. And I said well look if you're asking me I'm not about to say no to Donaldson. And I did and I became like a son to him. He didn't have any sons, he just had two daughters. And I was brash and I loved him and he took a liking to me and he championed me and taught me a lot.

MR: Great.

JW: I can remember being on the road with him and he'd come to my room in the morning while I was still sleeping, and he'd come in, "Well what did you do last night Jimmy Wormworth?" and blah, blah, blah. And we'd talk and he'd stand in front of me, he'd go to the dresser in my room and stand in front of the mirror and look at his embouchure. Just feel it and press it and examine it and look at it. And one of his idols was Johnny Hodges at the time, curiously enough. Charlie Parker was his main idol, but he loved

Johnny Hodges, I think for his tone. And tone was such a big thing to Lou. And he has such a great tone. And he used to be I think even bigger back then, but he worked on it so much. And he practiced long tones. He was — he taught me a lot. He tried to encourage me to concentrate more on playing the time, just playing the beat on the cymbal, and less on embellishing — comping as it's called — with my left hand on the snare drum, commenting, filling in. "I'm going to tie your left hand behind your back." I'd be playing along [scats] finally I'd get tired [scats} and he'd say 'aah." It took me a long time before I realized that what he was trying to teach me was that — look, you have to crawl before you can walk and walk before you can run. And you are very talented and you know a lot about music but I'd like to see you concentrate more on just playing the rhythm, keeping the time. Because you know already, you listen and you know when you make good comments, good embellishments with your left hand and with the bass drum, that's all fine. But you're only twenty, twenty-one years old and you still can learn how to broaden your effect — broaden what you do. Play the time. Learn how to play the time even better. And it took me a long time before I realized that but I wasn't about to argue with him. I just felt fortunate and grateful that somebody that was an idol of mine, artistically speaking would want me to be associated with him artistically. And he stood up for me quite a bit. And through him I met Peck Morrison, the bassist, who was Lou's bassist, man at the time, and we became close. And well I had already met Horace Parlan but we worked together with Lou Donaldson and really became close. And he recommended — well he didn't recommend me to Mingus, but we worked together with Charlie Mingus for a short time. Charlie Mingus used to come in the Five Spot too when I was working there with Mal Waldron as the house rhythm section. And one time he just asked me to work with him. His regular drummer, his favorite drummer was the late Danny Richmond, but they seemed to have a love-hate relationship. Every two weeks or so Mingus would fire Danny and hire somebody else. And then they'd make up after another two or three days so he'd fire whoever was in effect the sub. And Danny would be back. And that went on.

MR: Mingus pretty much taught Danny Richmond how to play didn't he?

JW: Danny was a saxophonist, a tenor saxophonist. He was from Lou Donaldson's home town, Greensboro, North Carolina. I don't know about that.

MR: It seems like I'd read that somewhere but it may not be true.

JW: Well I never heard that.

MR: Okay. Well let me try—

JW: I think Danny had started playing the drums before he came to New York. I never heard Danny play the saxophone.

MR: How about Elvin Jones?

JW: I met Elvin when he worked with J.J. Johnson's quintet with Tommy Flanagan, Wilbur Little and Bobby Jaspar, the Belgian saxophonist, in Amsterdam. I had heard about him through Al Levitt, the late Al Levitt, the drummer who was from New York and played with Lenny Tristano and Stan Getz and Lee Konitz and well quite a few other people. I had heard of Al through reading about his name in *Down Beat*, on records. And he was in Holland the first time I went to Europe, working with Pia Beck, the Dutch pianist, who had enjoyed some popularity in the middle and late 50s, and she worked the summer at a club outside of the Hague, at a resort called Skathagian. And these guys I was there with, a college Dixieland band, somehow wrangled a booking playing the intermissions opposite Pia Beck and I got to know Al Levitt there, we became fast friends. And I think he was really the one who first told me about Elvin. He tried to describe Elvin's playing to me. He said, "It sounds like all these little explosions." It didn't mean anything to me. And then the next summer I took my own band to Europe and I don't remember how we got hooked up but we ended up opening this concert at the Concertgebouw in Amsterdam for J.J.'s quintet. And Elvin was the drummer. And that's where I first heard him and met him. And after the concert we all retired to the Scheherazade Club, which was THE jazz club in Amsterdam at the time, and some of us sat in. And Elvin sat in. And I couldn't believe what I was hearing man. It sounded completely different than anything I had heard before by a jazz drummer. It just triggered all kinds of things in my imagination. It sounded like slow motion. It was like nothing I ever heard before.

MR: Did you like it?

JW: Yeah I liked it, yeah I definitely liked it. I was impressed. It was like revolutionary. It seems like — well I've read Elvin played polyrhythms, one rhythm against another rhythm and so forth, and it did kind of sound like that actually. At the same time it still was rooted in the tradition of Max Roach, Art Blakey, Jo Jones and so forth. But it was like nothing I had ever heard before. It was kind of revolutionary to me. He seemed to incorporate all the drums more than anybody had before into his total persona. You didn't just hear the cymbal, you heard everything — it was like ten different things going on at once. And he didn't know me. I guess maybe he heard me play before, I don't know, maybe he was in the dressing room. We spoke and, but then I got to New York, let's see, well actually it was that fall. That was in the summer of '57. In October of '57 I moved to New York. And I don't think I saw much of Elvin until I moved to the lower east side in January of '59 I think it was. And Elvin just so happened to have the same landlord as I did but in a building a block away from me. And I think he came in the Five Spot while I was working there. He was still working with J.J. I think. And the next thing I know he just started asking me — he started sending me on subs.

MR: Really?

JW: He sent me — I think the first sub he sent me on was with Tyree Glenn's quartet. And Tyree had like a sort of happy hour gig at The Round Table on 50th Street and Third Avenue, which was a pretty popular restaurant at the time. It had medieval décor and his quartet was Tommy Flanagan, Tommy Potter and Elvin. And they used to do remotes on Kate Smith's afternoon show which came on I think at four o'clock, which was like the precursor of Mike Douglas' show. In fact I think that was from Philly too. And she'd feature Tyree periodically on her show doing a remote from The Round Table. But anyway Elvin sent me on that and then he sent me to sub with Harry Edison and Jimmy Forrest's quintet, which had the same rhythm section, Tommy Flanagan, Tommy Potter and Elvin. And I subbed for Elvin a couple of times with that band. And he sent me on a couple of record dates. One was with a woman who sang and whistled. She was sort of like a folk singer, I don't know if anybody's — well I'll have to ask Elvin if he remembers who she was. I think he's the only one who is alive who — Dick Katz — well no, the pianist was Jimmy Jones, the bassist was George Duvivier, and it was just a four piece rhythm section. The guitarist was Barry Galbraith and the drummer was supposed to be Elvin. But he sent me. And we did the date. I remember she sang I guess blues and whistled a couple of choruses. I never did find out who she was.

MR: That's funny.

JW: I can't ask Tommy, he's gone, I can't ask either one of the Tommys, they're both gone. Elvin I think is the only one who I can ask. George Duvivier is gone.

MR: Before I forget I need to ask you about this Hamilton College connection that I just learned about tonight with you.

JW: Well in I guess the spring of 1956 Ronnie Zito may have contacted me to ask me if I wanted to go to Europe with these college guys who played Dixieland. And a couple of them went to Hamilton College and so forth. I don't think I knew them. Either that or he recommended me to them. And to make a long story short I went with them. Ronnie's mother wouldn't let him go. So I went. And I became fast friends with almost all of them. A couple were Hamilton College students, I think one, the clarinet player, was a graduate. The pianist went to Colgate, and the trumpet player went to Colgate. Although I thought he went to Hamilton until I recently learned that he didn't. And we played for our passage. There were these student sailings, student cruises, to Europe and back. They dropped you off in late June after school let out and they picked you up in late August and took you back home. And the ship had cabins, dormitories and with different prices. And there was a whole bunch of college kids. And we played for our passage. And it was pretty enjoyable. That's where I met Al Levitt and Pia Beck in Holland, which is where we were based, and then we rented two cars and became tourists and traveled around Belgium, France, about halfway down Italy and then a couple of places in Germany. We

mostly stayed in Hague. We worked for about a month in the Hague, well in the resort Skathington outside the Hague, and then we just did sightseeing the rest of the time. And another guy who I met around the same time who was a Hamilton College student had taken a band himself, his name was George Rutter. I can't remember what he played. Piano. He lives in St. Louis now. I was on the way to California and I don't remember — oh I know, Lou Donaldson was in St. Louis and George Rutter went, this is fifteen years or so ago, George Rutter went to see him and I think he had seen that I worked with Lou, he had the record that I made with Lou Donaldson, and so he knew I had worked with Lou Donaldson and he just introduced himself to Lou and talked, and then he sent me a letter and sent me a picture he had taken with Lou. That's how I knew George Rutter lived in St. Louis. And so on the way out to California one time I had a layover in St. Louis and called him from the airport. But anyways he took a band the same year. He was a Hamilton College student. And the next year he was offered the opportunity to take a band again but for whatever reasons he couldn't or didn't want to, and asked me was I interested and so I said yeah and I took my band. Unfortunately for us, for me, the guys in my band didn't want to play Dixieland. They just wanted to play Bebop. And we alienated ourselves from the crew, the company, and most of the passengers pretty quick. We had a little clique following but, and then to make matters worse on the way back those guys just mutinied altogether and wouldn't play half of the time. "What are they going to do, throw us off the boat?" I says, "Look man, I'm the leader here" blah, blah, blah. Taking the guys uniforms and everything, got us hooked up with gigs all over Europe, none of you would have gone to Europe for years to come. "Oh the hell with you." And I heard from the Holland America line after that. "We'll never hire you again."

MR: But the one group ended up doing a gig at Carnegie Hall?

JW: Yeah.

MR: What was the name of the group?

JW: That was in the fall after we returned home from our European trip. It wasn't actually a tour.

MR: Yeah, right.

JW: The Catatonic Five.

MR: The Catatonic Five.

JW: And when we were lucky enough to get augmented with a bass player it was The Catatonic Five Plus One. And for guys who weren't going to make music a career, I thought they played pretty well. The pianist played really well. He had excellent technique. He was pretty accomplished. They all played pretty well actually. But none of them became professional musicians.

MR: Some of them are still playing I think.

JW: Yeah. Donn Andre plays, the trombonist retired, Dr. Phil Mead plays, I think Emerson Brown, the clarinetist plays.

MR: Yes he does.

JW: And according to what they told me in correspondence, which I just got from them recently, they return to Hamilton almost every year and play.

MR: Yeah they do.

JW: And Donn Andre is asking me if I'd be in Utica around that time. The first week of June.

MR: Yeah they rip it up. Yes indeed. Reunion Weekend.

JW: Yeah we were pretty lively. We were a pretty good band actually.

MR: That'd be nice to have you up there.

JW: Yeah I'd love to come. Do you know, when I was a teenager I guess I was sixteen or so, I don't remember how but I met Mike Parker, whose father Paul was a professor at Hamilton. And Mike was really, really talented. He could really play some trumpet. He was attached to the thirties era musically, artistically. But talent is talent.

MR: What's your opinion of the state of jazz now?

JW: Well that's a good question. In some ways it seems to be a little better off than it was thirty years ago or so, or forty years ago. In some ways it seems different. The artists don't control it. The people outside the music control it and determine what gets heard, and determine who is recognized as an artist or as a non-artist. To me that's the way it always was. And to me that's the way it is today. My kids, especially two, well all three of my daughters, are friends with the Marsalis brothers. And my middle daughter went to Berklee College of Music with Branford. And my oldest daughter is the former fiance of the late Kenny Kirkland, who was in Wynton's original band. And well I don't know their father personally, we never met, but I can remember when he used to come up from New Orleans two weeks every summer to sub for Ellis Larkins, the great pianist, who for years played solo piano at the Carnegie Tavern on 56th Street in the back of Carnegie Hall. And Ellis Larkins was legendary among a lot of musicians. And the first I heard of Ellis Marsalis was when Ellis Larkins hired him to come here and play, take his place when Ellis Larkins went on vacation. And the next thing I know I'm hearing about these kids, who are his kids and who came up here and started going to school at Juilliard and at Berklee in Boston and my daughter Mary is close to Branford. Actually all three of my daughters are pretty close to Branford, and somewhat close to Wynton as well. But I can't understand how somebody like Larry Ridley, who helped found the Rutgers jazz program, which I think is recognized as one of the premier university jazz curricula in the world, wasn't asked to do that. Well maybe at the time that Lincoln Center decided they wanted to incorporate jazz into Lincoln Center's sphere, Larry was still a professor at

Rutgers. He's retired now and has gone back to playing. There are other people I can think of who to me are the wise men of the music, the giants.

MR: Yeah. I think it's the same exact question about why was he chosen as the spokesman for the Ken Burns thing?

JW: Yeah right.

MR: And I think there is some weight to, they probably want a younger spokesman.

JW: And I can't understand why, I mean Max Roach, Jackie McLean are pretty articulate. They certainly been involved in the teaching of the music at a high level long before Wynton ever became involved, and even going to school let alone teaching it.

MR: Well Tracy has had a pretty good run—

JW: My daughter Tracy?

MR: In music so far.

JW: Yeah. She has. She started playing late. She studied dance. She studied at Martha Graham and at ABT and then she went to SUNY up in Brockport as a dance major. She got discouraged, I think her physical appearance discouraged her and she dropped out and came back to New York and met a young musician who I had worked with a couple of times and they became close and he bought her a bass and she bought herself a Rubank book and just—

MR: Get out.

JW: Yeah. She's self taught completely.

MR: Wow. That's something.

JW: In six months she was working. In two years she was working with Phyllis Hyman. Yeah she's done really well. They showed musical talent — my middle daughter, when she was four, could sing any note I could hit on the piano. I'd try to play the most unlikely, the oddest intervals, F to B, octave low to B flat or to A or whatever. And I'd say, "Sing it honey" and she was four years old. The keyboard came up to here on her and she'd sing it clear as a bell. Any interval I could think. I'd just hit intervals at random, the oddest intervals. And I knew right then, man a four year old kid who can do that, she's got a great sense of relative pitch. And my older son, Jimmy, he'd play on the table or on the chair with his fingers, absent mindedly, along with something on the radio or a record of mine. And he used to astound me, the things he thought of at eight years old. He kind of used to browbeat me because I thought he could pick up some things, rhythmic figures and accompaniment, that I couldn't think of. He could play complicated six-eight rhythms in the third grade. So to me it was obvious that the two of them were really talented. But Tracy, my oldest one, it wasn't so obvious to me. Dancing I could see at a young age that she was well coordinated and she could hear the beat and so forth. But it

wasn't until she started playing that she just astounded me. To me she really is a great player, one of my favorite bass players. And I don't say that because she's my daughter.

MR: Do you get to work together?

JW: We have a couple of times but not much. She's graceful, she's both imaginative and practical, she's meticulous, devoted to anything that she perceives as being of importance. You add that up and you've got a good studio musician.

MR: Good. Well we're about to run out of tape here, it's really been fascinating talking.

JW: I can't believe this has been an hour?

MR: I know, it's been more.

JW: Oh man I could tell you so much more.

MR: Well we'll have to do another part.

JW: One thing I'd like to add, Utica really outdid itself so to speak in the amount of talent that both resided there and came from there, just in the area of music. Whether it's John Simonelli, who I think became the first chair hornist with the Philadelphia who played under Mason Jones. We played in all city high school band together. I could tell he was great then. He had an incredible sound on the French horn. He used to walk around rehearsal room before we started band rehearsal playing [scats] like that. I knew then, I was like thirteen or fourteen, I said wow, man, what a great sound that kid has. He was a little bit of a jokester but he became a world class French hornist. And well Torrie Zito, his accomplishments pretty much speak for themselves, all the arrangements he did for Tony Bennett of course, and something that maybe not too many people know now, he wrote the original Maxwell House jingle [scats].

MR: Oh no kidding?

JW: Yeah, that's Torrie.

MR: And you've got the Mancusos, and a Montalbano. Lots of great people.

JW: There are so many people, J.R. Monterose. My father, my uncle.

MR: And yourself.

JW: Uh I'm lucky to be part of a good wave.

MR: Right. Well thanks for your time today.

JW: Oh my pleasure.

MR: I really appreciate it man.

JW: My pleasure, Monk

MR: It's been great talking to you.

JW: I appreciate Hamilton including me.

MR: All right.

JW: And it's definitely heartwarming, not to mention encouraging, to know that Hamilton has this project happening.

MR: All right.

JW: That's my hometown territory.

MR: You got it. Thanks a lot.